

Holy and Hilarious

In the hands of Somya Satsangi, nuns walk beside penguins and sacred figures keep unlikely company – a lifetime of being the new girl in a new place, turned into a language all her own.

Somya Satsangi did not set out to become a painter of contradictions. She became one the way most people become anything — by moving house too many times to count.

She spent her childhood following her Military father's postings across India's landscapes: the Himalayas one year, the deserts of Rajasthan the next, a new school and a goodbye to go with it, a wardrobe of uniforms that never stayed the same for long. "My initiation into art was inseparable from the landscapes of my childhood," she says. "These terrains continue to reverberate in my paintings." What followed was further displacement — years spent living between Munich, London and Paris, with stretches across the United States — before a return to India let her see everything she thought she already knew with a stranger's eyes.

The art itself came slowly, and from more than one direction. She studied photography at a school in London, then trained formally in painting after coming back to Delhi, carrying with her a restless appetite for stories that had nothing to do with painting at all — Indian mythology, the Arabian Nights, Latin American magical realism, the dreamlike unease of Murakami. "These influences taught me that symbols are fluid, belonging to everyone, interpreted uniquely by each", she says, "and that life itself is a tapestry of contradictions." Each person who meets them, she suggests, reads them differently — the same Kali, the same nun, interpreted uniquely by whoever is looking. It is not a small claim, and it shows up literally on her canvases: a nun and a penguin, equally solemn, walking the same road; Kali standing at the helm of Noah's ark; Pikachu turning up, entirely unbothered, in a room full of friends.





Somya Satsangi
Artist

Across her artworks, religion and humour become less subjects in themselves than ways of approaching a question she has spent a lifetime answering sideways: what does it take to feel at home somewhere, and what do you carry with you when you keep having to leave? Her body of work is still being written, in every sense — more canvases, likely more company for her nuns before she is done.

Scenographer Rajeev Sethi, awarded the Padma Bhushan, put the difficulty of describing this work better than most: "How does one express a visual metaphor that words fail? Somya is conjuring imagery with layered narratives that masterfully open hidden probabilities of worlds within worlds."

Rajeev Sethi
Scenographer

Perhaps those "worlds within worlds" are also Satsangi's way of making home portable. The landscapes change, the symbols migrate, and unlikely companions meet—but somewhere between the nun and the penguin, belonging becomes possible.